were also surprised to see HP participating, a brand not known for cameras, and given that they sent us only one model, this was a sort of fluke. A basic, but well built camera, with an IS on/off button near the shutter key, and some tacky menu buttons. We liked its viewfinder that was shockingly better than some costlier cameras, like the Canon SX130 IS. The Nikon Coolpix L24 was perhaps the most basic camera in terms of feature set, and doesn't even allow one to change the ISO setting, let alone shutter speed and aperture. The Fujifilm JV200 has a metal body, and looks a little better than the plainer Fujifilm J40. It also has a marginally longer zoom of 6.7x, which is pretty versatile for daily shooting.

The Canon IXUS 105 was the most basic Canon digital camera in this comparison, but it looked smarter than its costlier sibling the IXUS 130 with a matte-brushed aluminium finish. About the only feature it misses is the lack of 720p video recording, although when it came to image quality too, it seems the IXUS 130 takes the lead in the ISO tests, despite having a higher megapixel count that generally makes such tiny sensors produce more noise.

We liked Canon's menus - they're fairly well laid out with a good many intuitive settings. Obviously, Canon has one basic menu layout that they follow, and their cheaper cameras simply have less menu options, while retaining the same structure. The HP CB350 had a fairly decent menu, while the Nikon Coolpix L24 had the most basic menu, not even allowing manual ISO control.

Performance

To get things into perspective, image quality isn't excellent or even very good, but it's good enough for what you pay, and shooting in daylight will get you good output. The HP CB350 starts to show noise at ISO 400, and this is visible even without looking at 100 per cent crops. None of the cameras in this category are immune from noise, not even the Canon IXUS 105, and noise smatters detail at ISO 800 onwards – graininess, loss of even coarser details and the image starts to look fuzzy at ISO 1600. Obviously, with such cameras, you're not looking to shoot at such settings, although the feature is available for emergency use. Also at ISO 3200, the HP CB350 and Fujifilm J40 interpolate the image, giving you a much smaller resolution of 3 megapixels; therefore ISO 3200 is not really a usable feature on these cameras.

The one thumb rule when shopping on a shoestring budget is to buy the cheapest available camera with a decent feature set and acceptable performance. There's no point spending 50 per cent more, for something that performs 20 per cent better. If you really want something significantly better, you'd be better off spending 10,000 bucks or more. If we had to pick a camera that impressed us the most, it would be the Fujifilm Finepix JV200 – we just couldn't resist the allure of a good performer coupled with the 6.7x optical zoom – a versatile package. It was another that took the accolade of our Best Buy – the HP CB350, mainly for the 50 per cent smaller hole it will burn in your pocket, for 4,000 bucks you cannot ask for much more. Well... maybe slightly better performance and a Lithium Ion battery.

₹8,001 TO ₹15,000: IS MIDDLE GROUND THE BEST?

You're obviously a little more serious if you're looking to blow

HOW WE TESTED

We divided our test candidates firstly on the basis of the type of camera – compact point-and-shoot, ultra zoom and advanced point-and-shoots. In advanced point and shoots, we further segregated compact cameras like the Canon S95 and Nikon P7000 and removable lens cameras like the Sony NEX-5 and Olympus EPL-1. While some might consider these dSLRs in the strictest sense, the simple fact remains that manufacturers aren't selling them that way. We're also moving into a market scenario where these cameras compete with dSLRs at a similar price range, and give up very little, except a proper viewfinder and a larger, better laid out set of controls. After category based segregations were done, we further divided these categories on the basis of price. For ultra zooms we didn't, because these cameras didn't seem to differ on features to a large extent.

Once again, we've given build quality and ergonomics a separate category of its own, and in terms of weights, features and build/ergonomics got 30 and 20 respectively, with 50 points going to performance. Our features and build/ergonomics is pretty self explanatory, but for performance we used a number of scenarios. Firstly, we set up a studio scene which we've attached a photo of here. This scene consists plastic flowers, cloth, fake fruit, colour pencils, paper clips and a couple of other elements. These elements were chosen as tests of various parameters of a cameras sensor


Test scene

and optical system. Detailing on flowers is a test, as is the subtle nuances of colour change on the petals, and texture and detailing on the surface – this tests a cameras dynamic range as well as the resolving capability of sensor and lens. For our quality test consisting of detail and dynamic range, we used a setting of ISO 100, an aperture of f5.6, a shutter speed of 1/5 second, while keeping the cameras mounted on the tripod to prevent shake. Centre weighted metering and auto white balance was used, and flash was disabled. Some cameras that didn't have manual control over settings like aperture and shutter speed, we set the ISO at 100, and then took the shot. Additionally, this scene was captured using flash in a dark room to check flash performance, toning down to prevent overexposure and so on. We also took shots at ISO 400, 800, 1600, 3200 and 6400 (for cameras that supported these) to check the performance of the sensor in "high gain" mode. Focussing accuracy was tested outdoors, by focussing on a building edge at both wide and long end of the zoom, and on some shrubbery in our office. For all these tests we worked with 100% crops, and at times, had as many as 5 images open – the outputs of different cameras being compared.

For testing video quality we played back the files on our test PC and also checked for audio quality. All these scores, including the still images were rated subjectively on a scale of 10.